

# HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת במדבר  
כח' אייר תשפ"ו  
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## By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-אI תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini:  
Did the AI get it right? Do you find

it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Morai veRabbosai, as we open Parshas Bamidbar, we face what seems to be the Torah's version of a tedious CPA audit. Hashem commands Moshe to count Bnei Yisroel, detailing the figures for every Shevet. Rashi (Bamidbar 1:1) famously points out that this counting is an expression of deep chibah from the Ribbono Shel Olam; because they are so precious to Him, He counts them constantly. Now, counting things constantly is usually a sign of intense neurosis, not affection. If you count your kugel slices every five minutes to ensure none vanished, it is not because you love the kugel, it is because you fundamentally distrust your children. Yet, Midrash Tanchuma (Bamidbar 4) explains that Hashem's counting elevates the neshama of each Yid. The danger of a census is the ayin hara, but when the Ribbono Shel Olam initiates the count, the exact opposite occurs. It transforms a faceless tzibbur into a collection of irreplaceable yechidim. He counts Bnei Yisroel to demonstrate that despite the massive multitudes trekking through the midbar, not a single Yid is a rounding error. Every individual has a tachlis that justifies their existence in the machaneh, which is comforting when you are squeezed between three people at kiddush trying to reach the cholent. This intense focus on the unique value of the yachid brings us directly to the second major theme of the Parsha, which is the agonizingly precise seating chart of the machaneh. Bamidbar 2:2 details how each Shevet camped by its degel, arranged exactly around the Mishkan. Ramban (Bamidbar 2:2) notes that this exact configuration was a direct continuation of the formation the Shevatim maintained around the mitah of Yaakov Avinu. Why such militant insistence on staying in your designated spot? Because just as the counting established that every Yid counts, the degalim established that every Yid counts right where they are. We are obsessed with seating arrangements in our shul; if a guest accidentally sits in the makom kavua of the Gabbai, you would think he dismantled the Aron Kodesh. But the underlying spiritual truth is the same. Seforno (Bamidbar 2:2) emphasizes that each degel represented a different derech in avodas Hashem. You cannot take the derech of Zevulun and force it onto Yissachar. Hashem counted us individually with chibah to show we matter, and then immediately gave us a specific degel to show exactly how we matter. The rigidity of the encampment was not a punishment; it was the ultimate validation that your specific kochoh is indispensable to the shleimus of the entire tzibbur. The **practical takeaway** for our avodas Hashem is profound. We often suffer from a spiritual identity crisis, looking at the shtender of the Yid next to us and assuming his degel is somehow more chashuv than ours. We think that if we are not learning or davening exactly like him, we are failing. Parshas Bamidbar teaches us that the Ribbono Shel Olam orchestrated the midbar so that every person has a unique makom. Your job is not to sneak into someone else's shevet because their flag has a nicer logo. Your job is to recognize the chibah Hashem showed by counting you, figure out the specific tachlis of your degel, and serve Him from those exact coordinates. May we all be zoche to stand proudly by our own degel, and may the Gabbai finally forgive the person who sat in his chair during Maariv.

## News & Simchos!

### Mazel Tov

To the Mendlowitz Family  
on the birth of a baby girl  
*Fancy Kiddush After Davening*

### To the Edelstein Family

on the birth of a baby girl  
*Kiddush To Be Announced*

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## Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

|                                               |                      |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| 2:30 pm                                       | מנחה                 |
| 6:37/7:50 pm                                  | הדלקה (Early/Late)   |
| --- pm                                        | מנחה - קבלת שבת      |
| 8:08 pm                                       | שקיעה                |
| 3:57/4:25 am                                  | עלות השחר (16.1/72)  |
| 5:37 am                                       | נץ החמה              |
| 7:15 am                                       | שחרית                |
| <b>Hot kiddush &amp; Shiur after davening</b> |                      |
| 8:39/9:15 am                                  | סיור קריאת שמע       |
| 10:03/10:28 am                                | סיור תפילה           |
| 12:53 pm                                      | חצות היום            |
| 1:29 pm                                       | מנחה גדולה (גר"א)    |
| 5:07 pm                                       | מנחה קטנה (גר"א)     |
| 6:38 pm                                       | פלג המנחה (גר"א)     |
| --- pm                                        | מנחה                 |
| 8:09 pm                                       | שקיעה                |
| 8:56/8:59 pm                                  | צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50) |
| 9:01 pm                                       | מעריב (52)           |
| 9:09/9:21 pm                                  | צה"כ (60/72)         |



## In Two Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

|              |                    |
|--------------|--------------------|
| 2:30 pm      | מנחה               |
| 6:47/8:02 pm | הדלקה (Early/Late) |
| 8:20 pm      | שקיעה              |
| 7:15 am      | שחרית              |
| 8:21 pm      | שקיעה              |
| 9:13 pm      | מעריב (52)         |

## This Week's Riddle

**Riddle: Which nasi (tribal leader) has the same first name as a nasi (national president) in the time of the second Bais HaMikdash?**

**Answer:** Gamliel ben Pedatzur, from the tribe of Menasheh (Bamidbar 1:10), shares a first name with the famous nasi and great sage of the second Bais HaMikdash era - Rabbai Gamliel.



## Donations & Payments

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## משל ונמשל ב-א' תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

**Mashal:** Morai veRabbosai, imagine a wealthy gvir who owns a sprawling real estate empire. Since the inception of the company, the ironclad policy was that the oldest son of every regional manager automatically received a corner office and a seat on the executive board the moment he turned twenty-two. For decades, these bechorim strolled into headquarters, put their feet up on mahogany desks, and enjoyed the prestige of their unearned positions. Then, a catastrophic market crash hits. A rival firm offers a highly illegal, completely fraudulent investment scheme—the corporate equivalent of a golden calf. In a moment of sheer panic, almost the entire company, including the entitled bechorim, signs onto this disastrous scam. Only one small department—the accounting clerks from one specific family—refuses to touch the fraudulent contracts. They withstand the immense peer pressure, risking their livelihoods to protect the gvir's assets. When the dust settles, the gvir calls a company-wide meeting. He orders the bechorim to pack up their desks and hands the loyal accounting clerks the keys to the executive suites. The gvir declares: a corner office is no longer a biological guarantee. It is a privilege reserved exclusively for those who demonstrated absolute loyalty when the rest of the boardroom lost their minds.

**Nimshal:** This corporate restructuring is the exact dynamic we witness in Parshas Bamidbar. Originally, the sacred avodah in the Mishkan was designated for the bechoros. As Hashem states explicitly, the bechoros were sanctified to Him during Makas Bechoros in Mitzrayim (Bamidbar 3:13). They had the ultimate yichus; they were slated to be the elite kohanim of Klal Yisroel by sheer virtue of their birth order. However, the tragic debacle of the Cheit HaEgel completely upended this arrangement. According to Rashi (Bamidbar 3:12, citing Zevachim 112b), the bechoros lost their mandate because they participated in the avodah zarah of the Egel. When Moshe Rabbeinu shouted, "Mi L'Hashem Eilai," the bechoros were noticeably silent. It was solely the Shevet Levi who rallied to Moshe's side, demonstrating phenomenal mesiras nefesh to the Ribbono Shel Olam during a moment of national insanity. Consequently, Hashem executed a historic structural swap. The pesukim detail how the Leviim were officially selected to replace the bechoros for the avodah (Bamidbar 3:11-12). The Ramban (Bamidbar 3:14) elaborates on the meticulous counting of the Leviim from the age of one month to highlight their newly acquired status as dedicated servants of the Mishkan. The bechoros had inherent yichus, but because they compromised their principles, they were stripped of the avodah. The Leviim earned the eternal zechus of serving in the Mishkan entirely through their own courageous bechirah.

**Practical Takeaway:** The practical takeaway for our avodas Hashem is terrifying for anyone who relies a little too heavily on their family name. In our Litvish circles, we place a massive premium on yichus. We write shidduch resumes that read like a historical dissertation, proudly documenting that our great-grandfather shared a carriage with the Chofetz Chaim, or that our family has occupied the same mizrach row in shul since the invention of central heating. We sometimes fall into the trap of the original bechoros, assuming that our prestigious lineage secures our shtender in the Beis Medrash. Parshas Bamidbar delivers a devastating reality check: yichus might get you an aliyah, but it does not guarantee your spiritual success. The Ribbono Shel Olam does not grant the avodah based on who your zeidy was; He grants it based on how you respond when the world around you is worshipping an egel. Your family tree is completely irrelevant if you are not willing to stand up and answer "Mi L'Hashem Eilai" when it actually matters. The Leviim teach us that true chashivus is not inherited through genetics; it is forged through uncompromising dikduk b'mitzvos, intense hasmadah, and an absolute refusal to conform to spiritual mediocrity. We must stop relying on the zechus avos of our ancestors and start acting like the Leviim, earning our makom through genuine yegiah. Otherwise, we might find ourselves respectfully asked to hand over the keys to the avodah to someone who actually earned them.

# GOOD SHABBUS!